

"Trust in Translation" - Branching Scenario

SCENARIO CHARTER

Problem Statement:

Alex sends a message to their colleague Priya that gets misinterpreted due to tone and cultural differences. The misunderstanding creates tension, and Alex needs to recognize the breakdown and use repair language to restore the working relationship.

Learning Objective:

By the end of this scenario, learners will practice perceiving when their message hasn't landed clearly, using repair language to clarify meaning, and adjusting tone to support verbal clarity.

Success Signal:

Learner can identify signs of miscommunication, select effective repair phrases, and understand how tone/body language affects message reception across cultures.

Context:

Alex (direct communicator) and Priya (indirect, relationship-focused communicator) work together remotely on a marketing campaign. A quick message from Alex about project changes is misunderstood by Priya, creating tension. Alex must repair the misunderstanding.

FULL BRANCHING SCRIPT WITH DECISIONS

SLIDE 1: INTRODUCTION (Situation Setup)

Title: When Messages Don't Land

Narration/Text:

"You're Alex, a marketing coordinator working remotely with your colleague Priya on a client campaign. You've just reviewed Priya's draft social media posts and noticed they don't match the brand tone the client requested in yesterday's meeting.

You quickly send Priya a message: 'These posts don't really work. The tone is off.'

A few minutes later, you receive a very short reply from Priya: 'Okay.'

Usually Priya is friendly and collaborative in her messages. This response feels different. Something seems off."

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SLIDE 2: DECISION POINT 1 - Recognizing the Misunderstanding

Title: What do you do next?

Prompt: "You sense something might have gone wrong in your communication. How do you respond?"

OPTIONS:

- A)** "Wait to see if Priya follows up. Maybe she's just busy and nothing is wrong."
- B)** "Send another message: 'Hey, I might not have been clear in my last message. Can we jump on a quick call to talk through the direction together?'"
- C)** "Send a follow-up: 'I need you to understand what the client wants. Let me know when you can redo these.'"

Navigation:

- Option A → Slide 3A
 - Option B → Slide 3B
 - Option C → Slide 3C
-

SLIDE 3A: Consequence + Feedback (POOR CHOICE)

Dialogue Outcome:

Over the next two days, Priya's messages remain brief and formal. She stops asking questions in team meetings. The campaign deadline approaches, but the disconnect between you continues to grow.

Feedback to Learner:

✗ Incorrect Choice

Why this doesn't work:

You missed the signal that your message didn't land well. Priya's short "Okay" was a sign of withdrawal—a common response when someone feels criticized. By not addressing it, you let the misunderstanding damage your working relationship.

Reflection Prompt:

What were the signals that something was wrong? How might early repair have prevented this breakdown?

Cultural Insight:

In many cultures, indirect communicators won't explicitly say they're upset. They show it through changes in communication style—shorter messages, less warmth, reduced engagement. Learning to read these signals is key to effective cross-cultural communication.

Relationship Note:

Trust is eroding. Priya feels unappreciated and is pulling back from collaboration.

Navigation: [Try Again] → Slide 2 OR [Continue to See Resolution] → Slide 4

SLIDE 3B: Consequence + Feedback (BEST CHOICE)**Dialogue Outcome:**

Priya responds: "Thanks for reaching out. Yes, I'd appreciate that. I wasn't sure if I had done something wrong."

Feedback to Learner:

 **Correct Choice**

Why this works:

You recognized the signal (Priya's unusually short response) and took immediate action to repair. Your message:

- Acknowledged you might not have been clear ("I might not have been clear")
- Invited collaboration ("talk through the direction together")
- Showed you value the relationship (reaching out proactively)

Reflection Prompt:

What specific phrase helped Priya feel safe enough to reengage? How did taking ownership ("I might not have been clear") create space for repair?

Cultural Insight:

Proactive repair demonstrates emotional intelligence and cultural awareness. By inviting dialogue rather than assumptions, you bridge different communication styles effectively.

Relationship Note:

Trust is being actively repaired. Priya feels valued and is willing to collaborate.

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SLIDE 3C: Consequence + Feedback (POOR CHOICE)**Dialogue Outcome:**

Priya doesn't respond for several hours. When she finally does, her message is formal: "I will revise and send new drafts by end of day."

Feedback to Learner:

✗ Incorrect Choice

Why this doesn't work:

Instead of repairing the misunderstanding, you doubled down on the directive tone. "I need you to understand" and "redo these" sound like commands, not collaboration. This increases defensiveness and damages psychological safety.

Reflection Prompt:

How did this message make the situation worse? What tone did your words convey?

Cultural Insight:

Direct, commanding language can feel disrespectful in cultures that value relationship-building and collaborative decision-making. Your intent may have been efficiency, but the impact was alienation.

Relationship Note:

Trust is significantly damaged. Priya is now complying out of obligation, not engagement.

Navigation: [Try Again] → Slide 2 OR [Continue] → Slide 4

SLIDE 4: DECISION POINT 2 - Using Repair Language (Video Call)

Title: On the call with Priya

Context Text:

"You're now on a video call with Priya. She looks reserved—her camera is on, but her arms are crossed, and she's not making much eye contact. You need to repair the miscommunication from your earlier message."

Prompt: "How do you start the conversation?"

OPTIONS:

A) "Hey Priya, thanks for jumping on. I think my message earlier might have come across wrong. I didn't mean to sound harsh—I was just rushed and didn't explain the client feedback clearly. Can I walk you through what they said?"

B) "So, about those posts. The client specifically mentioned they want a more professional tone. Did you get that from the meeting notes?"

C) "I know you're probably upset about my message, but I was just trying to be direct and save time. Let's just focus on fixing the posts."

Navigation:

- Option A → Slide 5A
 - Option B → Slide 5B
 - Option C → Slide 5C
-

SLIDE 5A: Consequence + Feedback (BEST CHOICE)**Dialogue Outcome:**

Priya's shoulders relax slightly. She uncrosses her arms and makes eye contact. "Thank you for saying that. I thought maybe I had completely misunderstood the brief. I appreciate you clarifying."

Feedback to Learner:

 **Correct Choice - Excellent Repair Language**

Why this works:

You used effective repair language:

- **Took ownership:** "My message might have come across wrong"
- **Named the issue:** "didn't mean to sound harsh"
- **Explained context:** "I was rushed"
- **Offered collaboration:** "Can I walk you through..."

This approach doesn't assign blame—it creates space for clarity and rebuilds connection.

Reflection Prompt:

Notice Priya's body language change. What specific words or tone helped her feel safe to reengage?

Cultural Insight:

Taking responsibility for how your message landed (not just what you intended) shows cultural humility and strengthens trust across communication styles.

Relationship Note:

Trust is being actively restored. Priya feels respected and understood.

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SLIDE 5B: Consequence + Feedback (PARTIAL)**Dialogue Outcome:**

Priya's expression doesn't change. "Yes, I saw the notes. I tried to incorporate that feedback." Her tone is flat.

Feedback to Learner:

 Partially Correct

Why this needs improvement:

You moved straight to the work task without addressing the relational rupture first. While you're being clear about the client feedback, you haven't repaired the misunderstanding from your original message. Priya still feels criticized.

Reflection Prompt:

What's missing from this approach? How might addressing the relationship first change Priya's engagement?

Cultural Insight:

In relationship-focused cultures, addressing the emotional/relational aspect before diving into task details shows respect and prevents further disconnection.

Relationship Note:

Trust remains strained. The task may get done, but the relationship continues to suffer.

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SLIDE 5C: Consequence + Feedback (POOR CHOICE)

Dialogue Outcome:

Priya's face tightens. "I'm not upset. Let's just go over what needs to change." She sounds formal and detached.

Feedback to Learner:

 Incorrect Choice

Why this doesn't work:

You dismissed Priya's feelings ("I know you're probably upset, but...") and defended your behavior rather than taking responsibility for repair. This invalidates her experience and prevents genuine reconnection.

Reflection Prompt:

How did starting with "but" undermine any attempt at repair? What impact does dismissing someone's feelings have on trust?

Cultural Insight:

Telling someone how they feel or dismissing emotions damages psychological safety. Even if your intent was to move forward, the impact was further alienation.

Relationship Note:

Trust is severely damaged. Priya has emotionally checked out of the relationship.

Navigation: [Try Again] → Slide 4 OR [Continue] → Slide 6

SLIDE 6: DECISION POINT 3 - Adjusting Tone & Body Language

Title: Reading nonverbal cues

Context Text:

"You've started to repair the conversation. As you explain the client feedback, you notice Priya nodding but her expression is still uncertain. She's looking down at her notes more than at the camera."

Prompt: "What do you do to strengthen the repair?"

OPTIONS:

A) "Pause and say: 'I want to make sure we're on the same page. How are you feeling about this direction? Is there anything that's unclear or that you'd like to talk through?'"

B) "Continue explaining the client feedback in detail, making sure to cover all the points so nothing is missed."

C) "Say: 'Does this all make sense? Great, let me know if you have questions later.'"

Navigation:

- Option A → Slide 7A
 - Option B → Slide 7B
 - Option C → Slide 7C
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SLIDE 7A: Consequence + Feedback (BEST CHOICE)**Dialogue Outcome:**

Priya looks up and makes eye contact. "Actually, I'm still a bit confused about the tone shift. The client seemed happy with the casual approach in our first meeting. Can you help me understand what changed?"

Your conversation becomes collaborative. Together, you review the meeting notes and create examples of the new tone. By the end, Priya says, "This is really helpful. I feel much better about the direction now."

Feedback to Learner:

Correct Choice - Monitoring & Adjusting

Why this works:

You demonstrated all three learning objectives:

1. **Perceived** when your message hadn't landed (noticed Priya's uncertainty)
2. **Used repair language** (invited her perspective without pressure)
3. **Adjusted tone** (paused to check in rather than steamrolling ahead)

This created safety for Priya to ask clarifying questions, turning the misunderstanding into deeper collaboration.

Reflection Prompt:

How did pausing to check in change the quality of your conversation? What nonverbal cues told you adjustment was needed?

Cultural Insight:

Slowing down to ensure mutual understanding (even when it feels less efficient) builds trust and actually saves time by preventing future confusion.

Relationship Note:

Trust is fully restored and strengthened. The relationship is more resilient than before.

Navigation: [Continue] → Slide 8 (Conclusion)

SLIDE 7B: Consequence + Feedback (PARTIAL)

Dialogue Outcome:

You finish explaining all the details. Priya says, "Okay, I'll work on the revisions." She ends the call quickly.

Later, her revised posts still miss some of the tone adjustments. You're frustrated, and Priya seems confused about what went wrong again.

Feedback to Learner:

Partially Correct

Why this could be better:

You provided information but didn't check for understanding or create space for questions. Priya's nonverbal cues (looking down, uncertain expression) suggested she needed more support, but you didn't adjust to those signals.

Reflection Prompt:

What signals did you miss? How might checking in have prevented the continued confusion?

Cultural Insight:

In many cultures, people won't interrupt or ask questions if they feel the speaker is focused on delivering information. Creating explicit space for dialogue is essential.

Relationship Note:

Trust is neutral but fragile. The misunderstanding may repeat because underlying confusion wasn't addressed.

Navigation: [Continue] → Slide 8 (Conclusion)

SLIDE 7C: Consequence + Feedback (POOR CHOICE)

Dialogue Outcome:

Priya says, "Yes, makes sense," but her tone is flat. She doesn't ask any questions.

When she sends the revised posts, they still don't match the client's needs. The disconnect continues.

Feedback to Learner:

 **Incorrect Choice**

Why this doesn't work:

You closed the conversation without genuinely checking for understanding. "Does this make sense?" with an assumed "Great" doesn't invite authentic dialogue—it pressures quick agreement. You missed Priya's nonverbal signals of uncertainty.

Reflection Prompt:

How did rushing to close the conversation prevent real clarity? What's the difference between checking for understanding and seeking quick agreement?

Cultural Insight:

In cultures that value harmony, people may say "yes" or "makes sense" to avoid prolonging discomfort—even when they're still confused. True repair requires creating safety for honest questions.

Relationship Note:

Trust remains low. The pattern of miscommunication will likely continue.

Navigation: [Try Again] → Slide 6 OR [Continue] → Slide 8 (Conclusion)

SLIDE 8: CONCLUSION & LEARNER TAKEAWAY

Title: Building Trust Through Repair

Content:

Repair Language in Action:

You just practiced the critical skill of recognizing and repairing miscommunication. Here's what makes repair effective:

1. Perceiving When Messages Don't Land

Watch for signals:

- Changes in response length or warmth
- Body language shifts (crossed arms, lack of eye contact)
- Overly formal or brief responses
- Withdrawal from usual collaboration

2. Using Repair Language

Effective phrases include:

- "Let me rephrase that; I think I wasn't clear."
- "Can I try that again? I want to make sure I expressed myself correctly."
- "That didn't come out quite right. Here's what I meant."
- "I think we might be hearing this differently. Can we pause and reset?"
- "I'm not sure we're on the same page. Can you tell me what you heard?"

3. Monitoring Tone & Body Language

Remember: **60-70% of communication** is nonverbal

- Your tone and body language must match your repair words
- Pause to check for understanding, don't just deliver information
- Adjust when you notice uncertainty or disengagement

4. Cultural Awareness

Different cultures express and repair misunderstandings differently:

- Some cultures are direct about confusion; others signal it subtly
- Some prioritize efficiency; others prioritize relationship before task
- Adaptation and humility strengthen cross-cultural trust

Reflection Questions:

- How did early recognition of the misunderstanding change the outcome?
- Which repair phrases felt most authentic to you?
- What nonverbal cues did you notice throughout the scenario?
- How might you adapt these techniques to your own communication style?

Next Steps:

Over the next week, notice a moment when your message isn't landing. Use the repair strategies you practiced here:

1. Recognize the signal

2. Use repair language
3. Adjust your tone/approach
4. Check for genuine understanding

Use the **Misunderstandings Reflection Guide** to track when misunderstandings occur and how you repair them.

Confidence Check:

On a scale of 1-10, how confident do you feel now at repairing misunderstandings at work?

[Slider: 1-10]

Navigation: [Complete] → End / LMS Tracking

CONSEQUENCE MATRIX (Quick Reference)

Decision Point	Choice A	Choice B (Best)	Choice C
1. Recognition	Ignore signals (POOR)	Proactive repair message (BEST)	Double down (POOR)
Outcome	Relationship erodes	Trust being repaired	Defensiveness increases
2. Repair Language	Full repair with ownership (BEST)	Skip repair, focus on task (PARTIAL)	Dismiss feelings (POOR)
Outcome	Priya reengages	Tension remains	Emotional checkout
3. Tone & Adjustment	Check understanding (BEST)	Info dump (PARTIAL)	False closure (POOR)
Outcome	Collaboration deepens	Confusion persists	Misunderstanding repeats

VARIABLES & SCORING (for SCORM)

Tracking Variables:

- decision1_choice (A/B/C)
- decision2_choice (A/B/C)
- decision3_choice (A/B/C)
- total_score (calculated)
- confidence_before (1-10 scale)

- confidence_after (1-10 scale)

Scoring Logic:

- Best choice = 10 points
- Partial choice = 5 points
- Poor choice = 0 points

Passing Score: 20/30 (66%)

Completion Trigger: Reaching Slide 8 + completing confidence check

